

Why More Information Produces Less Shared Reality

Misinformation, Media Fragmentation, and Knowledge Decay

Reality Drift Framework — Problem Brief #4

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The Visible Problem

Modern societies have access to more information than any previous society.

News travels instantly.

Research is widely available.

Public events are documented in real time.

Experts can communicate directly with large audiences.

Search systems, social platforms, digital archives, and artificial intelligence make knowledge easier to produce and retrieve.

Yet shared reality is becoming harder to maintain.

People encounter misinformation, disinformation, information overload, media fragmentation, polarization, conspiracy theories, synthetic media, and declining trust in expertise.

These problems are usually treated separately.

One explanation focuses on bad actors.

Another focuses on social media.

Another focuses on political polarization.

Another focuses on platform incentives.

Another focuses on artificial intelligence.

Each explanation identifies something real.

But together they point toward a deeper structural problem:

Systems for producing and distributing information are expanding faster than the systems required to verify, correct, and integrate that information into shared knowledge.

The result is not a shortage of information.

It is informational abundance without stable grounding.

Why Existing Explanations Feel Incomplete

Misinformation is often treated as a content problem.

The assumption is that false claims enter an otherwise healthy information system.

Media fragmentation is treated as a distribution problem.

Different audiences receive different information.

Information overload is treated as an attention problem.

People cannot process everything available to them.

Polarization is treated as a political or social problem.

Groups interpret evidence through conflicting identities and commitments.

Synthetic media is treated as an authenticity problem.

Images, audio, video, and text become harder to verify.

These explanations describe different symptoms.

They do not fully explain why the same symptoms are appearing together.

The shared issue is not simply that some information is false.

It is that the systems responsible for determining what counts as reliable knowledge are becoming less able to maintain stable relationships between representation and reality.

The Shared Mechanism

Human beings do not encounter most public reality directly.

They encounter representations.

News represents events.

Research represents observations.

Statistics represent conditions.

Experts represent domains of knowledge.

Media systems represent the world beyond immediate experience.

These representations make large-scale knowledge possible.

They allow societies to coordinate around events that no individual could observe alone.

At first, the system works because representation remains connected to verification.

Claims can be checked.

Errors can be corrected.

Sources can be compared.

Knowledge can accumulate.

The shared mechanism changes as information production expands:

information expansion → attention optimization → representational abundance → verification
overload → epistemic drift

More information becomes available.

More people can produce content.

More systems can distribute it.

Platforms optimize for visibility, speed, engagement, amplification, and attention.

Representations become easier to create and circulate than to verify.

The volume of information increases faster than the capacity for correction.

The system remains active.

Its grounding mechanisms become comparatively weaker.

How Epistemic Drift Emerges

Information Expansion

Digital systems reduce the cost of producing and distributing information.

More claims, interpretations, images, narratives, and explanations enter circulation.

The information environment becomes richer.

It also becomes harder to evaluate.

Attention Optimization

Distribution systems must decide what becomes visible.

They increasingly optimize for engagement, speed, novelty, emotional intensity, and shareability.

The information most likely to circulate is not necessarily the information most strongly connected to reality.

Visibility becomes a proxy for relevance.

Representational Abundance

Information becomes easier to reproduce, remix, summarize, and reframe.

The same event appears through thousands of competing representations.

The problem shifts from access to selection.

People must decide which representations deserve trust.

Verification Overload

Correction remains slower and more expensive than production.

A false or misleading claim can be created in seconds.

Verifying it may require expertise, source access, institutional coordination, and time.

Representations multiply faster than verification can stabilize them.

Epistemic Drift

Communication remains constant.

Media remains active.

Information remains abundant.

Yet the relationship between circulating representations and underlying reality becomes progressively harder to establish.

The information survives.

The grounding becomes harder to maintain.

This is epistemic drift.

How the Failure Modes Connect

Misinformation

False or misleading claims spread through the same systems that distribute accurate information.

The distribution system works.

The distinction between truth and visibility weakens.

Media Fragmentation

Audiences increasingly inhabit separate channels, communities, and algorithmic environments.

Each group encounters a different representation of public reality.

Information expands.

Shared correction weakens.

Information Overload

People gain access to more information than they can evaluate.

The central problem becomes deciding what deserves attention and trust.

Access improves.

Judgment becomes more difficult.

Synthetic Media

AI-generated text, images, audio, and video increase the supply of plausible representations.

The content can appear coherent and convincing.

Its relationship to an actual event, source, or person becomes harder to establish.

Polarization

Groups interpret events through different informational environments.

The disagreement is not always about the same evidence.

The represented world itself differs across communities.

These failures look different on the surface.

Structurally, they all weaken the relationship between information systems and shared reality.

Why the System Still Looks Functional

Epistemic drift is difficult to detect because the visible indicators suggest success.

More information exists.

More people can publish.

More perspectives are available.

More events are documented.

More content can be searched and retrieved.

Communication becomes faster.

The information system appears increasingly productive.

But productivity is not the same as knowledge.

A system can generate more representations while becoming less capable of determining which representations deserve trust.

A platform can improve distribution while weakening verification.

A media environment can increase participation while fragmenting shared context.

An AI system can make information easier to summarize while also making synthetic representations easier to produce.

The infrastructure survives.

The capacity for shared grounding weakens beneath the appearance of informational abundance.

Reality Drift Interpretation

Within the Reality Drift framework, the epistemic crisis is not simply a rise in false information.

It is a representational failure.

Knowledge systems depend on representations remaining answerable to reality.

This requires more than transmission.

It requires correction, context, verification, source integrity, and shared standards for deciding what counts as evidence.

When optimization increasingly targets visibility, engagement, speed, and amplification, representations multiply faster than correction mechanisms can preserve Semantic Fidelity.

The result is not ignorance.

People may know more facts, encounter more perspectives, and access more sources than ever before.

The deeper failure is that society becomes less able to integrate those representations into a stable account of what is happening.

information → distribution → optimization → fragmentation → weakened verification →
epistemic drift

Shared reality does not disappear all at once.

It becomes harder to reconstruct.

Recognition Questions

Why does more information not always produce more knowledge?

Because knowledge requires verification, context, correction, and integration. Increasing the volume of information does not automatically strengthen those processes.

How does media fragmentation weaken shared reality?

Different groups receive different selections, framings, and interpretations of events. Shared correction becomes difficult when people no longer operate from overlapping informational environments.

Why does misinformation spread faster than verification?

Information can be produced and distributed almost instantly. Verification often requires time, expertise, evidence, and access to original sources.

What is the difference between misinformation and epistemic drift?

Misinformation is false or misleading content. Epistemic drift is the broader weakening of the system used to distinguish reliable knowledge from representation.

Why do people no longer know what to trust?

The visible signals of credibility, popularity, expertise, authenticity, and institutional authority have become easier to reproduce while their relationship to underlying reality has become harder to verify.

Core Principle

The epistemic crisis is not simply an increase in false claims. It is a weakening of the systems that correct, contextualize, verify, and integrate claims into shared knowledge.

Information becomes abundant while the relationship between information and reality becomes harder to maintain.

Society gains more representations of the world while becoming progressively less able to reconstruct a shared world from them.